

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

The Tughlaqs: Muhammad bin Tughlaq & Firuz Shah - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Medieval History 05 - The Tughlaqs

Muhammad bin Tughlaq and Firuz Shah compared through ambition, capacity, orthodoxy and durability

TOPIC-SPECIFIC COVER

Muhammad bin Tughlaq

- High ambition
- Second-capital logic
- Token currency
- Doab assessment
- Diwan-i-Kohi
- Khurasan / Qarachil
- Wider recruitment
- Caliphal rescript under pressure
- Innovation outruns compliance

Firuz Shah Tughlaq

- Reduced territorial horizon
- Elite conciliation
- Hereditary offices and iqta
- Canals and public works
- Diwan-i-Bandagan
- Charity and hospitals
- Separate jizya and sharper orthodoxy
- Succession softening after 1388

COMPARE, DON'T CARICATURE

Best lens

State capacity + source criticism

Key contrast

Innovation without compliance vs stability without central edge

Historical significance

Widest Delhi reach, Deccan consequences, canals, pre-Timur weakening

Schematic / not to scale where relevant. Source limits handled in surrounding text.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

The Tughlaqs: Muhammad bin Tughlaq & Firuz Shah - Solved Practice Workbook	3
BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION	3
Original broad-coverage MCQs	6
Semantic-completeness coverage drills - Medieval Topic 05	17
PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE	17
PYQ verification ledger and scope honesty	17
Verified and honestly-adjacent PYQs	18
Original solved Mains practice	20

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Rotation check rule: Every original sequence in this export rotates correct options **A -> B -> C -> D**. This section begins that cycle.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Learning MCQ 01

Question: Which statement best captures the significance of Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq's accession for Topic 05?

- A. It restored dynastic authority after late Khalji collapse and created the immediate institutional handoff into Muhammad's reign.
- B. It ended the need for any further Deccan campaigning by Delhi.
- C. It made Delhi's nobles permanently loyal to the new dynasty.
- D. It replaced all earlier administrative practices with a purely tribal order.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Ghiyasuddin's reign matters because it restored order after Khusrau Khan, revived consolidation and created the political platform inherited by Muhammad bin Tughlaq.

Learning MCQ 02

Question: Which statement about the Daulatabad move is the safest according to the local evidence used in this package?

- A. The move was a purely religious pilgrimage strategy.
- B. Daulatabad functioned as a second-capital project, with heavy pressure mainly on elites and service groups rather than the total population of Delhi.
- C. Delhi was fully depopulated and ceased to function.
- D. The policy had no long-term effect on the Deccan.

Answer: B.

Explanation: The source-backed line is that Daulatabad was a second-capital experiment. Pressure was coercive, but the total-emptying myth is not sustainable.

Learning MCQ 03

Question: Muhammad bin Tughlaq's token-currency experiment is best described as:

- A. a barter-reform policy replacing coinage with grain notes.
- B. a temple-donation currency used only in the Deccan.
- C. a copper-and-brass fiduciary coinage that failed because state control over authentication and counterfeiting was weak.
- D. an early paper-currency scheme copied from Europe.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The experiment used metal token coinage, not paper. Its key fault line was credibility and forgery control.

Learning MCQ 04

Question: The doab crisis under Muhammad bin Tughlaq is most convincingly explained by which combination?

- A. Purely peasant dislike of monetisation, without any climatic stress.
- B. A deliberate abolition of agriculture by the court.
- C. Peaceful refusal to migrate to Daulatabad.
- D. Rigid assessment, oppressive collection and famine-like environmental stress interacting with each other.

Answer: D.

Explanation: The best explanation combines policy, collection practices and climate. No one-cause story is sufficient.

Learning MCQ 05

Question: The Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi is most accurately associated with:

- A. state-backed cultivation extension, agricultural loans and attempts at crop improvement.
- B. organising the Topra pillar transport.
- C. creating a naval department for Gujarat.
- D. replacing the iqta system with village republics.

Answer: A.

Explanation: The department targeted agrarian extension and improvement through loans and supervision, though implementation failed badly.

Learning MCQ 06

Question: Which statement correctly distinguishes the Khurasan project from the Qarachil expedition?

- A. Khurasan succeeded fully while Qarachil never began.
- B. The Khurasan project concerned the north-western strategic frontier, whereas Qarachil was a Himalayan campaign shaped by terrain and logistics.
- C. Khurasan was a Bengal tax reform and Qarachil a canal.
- D. Both were attempts to conquer China.

Answer: B.

Explanation: The package stresses that the two enterprises must not be conflated. One is a frontier-strategy question; the other is a mountain-expedition problem.

Learning MCQ 07

Question: Barani's hostility to Muhammad bin Tughlaq's "low-born" or non-traditional appointees is most useful as evidence for:

- A. a democratic revolution in the Delhi Sultanate.
- B. the total absence of talent among those officials.
- C. aristocratic prejudice within the chronicler's own political world.
- D. the end of all provincial administration.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Barani's language reveals elite bias. It cannot simply be taken as proof that every such appointment was incompetent.

Learning MCQ 08

Question: Ibn Battuta is most valuable for Topic 05 when the historian wants to study:

- A. exact all-India revenue statistics over multiple decades.
- B. the architecture of Mauryan stupas.
- C. a neutral village-by-village survey of agrarian life.
- D. court ritual, roads, travel conditions, gift-punishment culture and the atmosphere of Muhammad bin Tughlaq's rule.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Ibn Battuta's strength lies in witnessed courtly practice and travel experience, not comprehensive structural statistics.

Learning MCQ 09

Question: Muhammad bin Tughlaq's religious politics are best understood as:

- A. observant but intellectually open kingship that still clashed with orthodox intermediaries and resorted to harsh coercion.
- B. pure saintly tolerance without punitive action.
- C. complete rejection of Islam in favour of a new state creed.
- D. total ulema domination from the beginning of the reign.

Answer: A.

Explanation: The local evidence shows observance, debate with multiple traditions, caliphal symbolism and sharp conflict with orthodox critics.

Learning MCQ 10

Question: Firuz Shah's accession strategy is best summarised as:

- A. ending all iqta assignments immediately.
- B. stabilising a smaller governable Sultanate through conciliation of nobles, soldiers and theologians.
- C. reconquering the entire south before consolidating Delhi.
- D. abolishing public works in favour of frontier war.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Firuz reduced horizon and emphasised conciliation rather than recreating Muhammad's scale of ambition.

Learning MCQ 11

Question: The hereditary transfer of offices and iqtas under Firuz Shah most directly encouraged:

- A. tighter central audit over nobles.
- B. meritocratic widening of recruitment.
- C. oligarchic closure and long-run weakening of central discipline.
- D. the abolition of village revenue assignments.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The policy reduced fear and rebellion in the short run, but it entrenched hereditary office-holding and weakened discipline.

Learning MCQ 12

Question: In the fiscal language of Firuz Shah's reign, **haqq-i-sharb** referred to:

- A. a customs duty on imported horses.
- B. a minting charge on copper coins.
- C. a war indemnity paid by Bengal.
- D. an irrigation-related water due collected from villages benefiting from canals.

Answer: D.

Explanation: The package uses the advanced OCR's clear identification of *haqq-i-sharb* as a water due tied to canal benefit.

Learning MCQ 13

Question: Firuz Shah's transport of Ashokan pillars to Delhi is historically significant primarily because it shows:

- A. technical skill, dynastic appropriation of older prestige and a politics of repair/reuse.
- B. the first printing press in the Sultanate.
- C. abandonment of urban building in favour of pilgrimage.
- D. the destruction of all pre-Islamic monuments in north India.

Answer: A.

Explanation: The pillar episode combines engineering, display and appropriation; it does not fit either pure vandalism or modern conservation.

Learning MCQ 14

Question: The Diwan-i-Bandagan under Firuz Shah is best interpreted as:

- A. a merchants' guild of Multan.
- B. an organised system of slave labour, training and political dependence attached to the court.
- C. a voluntary labour union.
- D. a frontier cavalry school for Mongol recruits only.

Answer: B.

Explanation: The slave institution supported workshops, palace service and armed dependence; it was not a welfare body.

Learning MCQ 15

Question: Which statement best captures Firuz Shah's religious policy?

- A. It completely ignored the ulema and abolished jizya.
- B. It replaced Islamic symbols with Persian royal ritual only.
- C. It combined political conciliation and benevolence with sharper juristic orthodoxy, including separate jizya and denial of Brahman exemption.
- D. It made all temple destruction narratives impossible by definition.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Firuz's reign reduced one kind of coercion while sharpening orthodox marking; that combination is the key.

Learning MCQ 16

Question: Which comparison between Muhammad bin Tughlaq and Firuz Shah Tughlaq is the most defensible?

- A. Muhammad failed because he had no coherent aims, while Firuz succeeded because he had none either.
- B. Muhammad and Firuz used identical instruments but got different luck.
- C. Muhammad was purely secular and Firuz purely religious.
- D. Muhammad pushed innovation and direct control beyond durable compliance, whereas Firuz purchased stability through conciliation that weakened long-run central power.

Answer: D.

Explanation: This package's central comparison rests on different state strategies, not on shallow moral labels.

Original broad-coverage MCQs

Rotation check rule: This second original sequence restarts at **A** and rotates strictly through **B, C, D**.

Broad MCQ 01

Question: Why does Topic 05 begin with Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq rather than only with Muhammad bin Tughlaq?

- A. Because Ghiyasuddin created the dynastic legitimacy and immediate political platform inherited by Muhammad.
- B. Because Firuz Shah belonged to the same branch of Rajputs.
- C. Because no Khalji ruler ever existed before him.
- D. Because Ghiyasuddin founded Vijayanagara.

Answer: A.

Explanation: The Tughlaq story begins with the 1320 takeover and Ghiyasuddin's consolidation, not only with Muhammad's experiments.

Broad MCQ 02

Question: Tughlaqabad is best understood as:

- A. a pleasure garden with no political meaning.

- B. a fortified dynastic statement of military austerity and new legitimacy.
- C. a Portuguese warehouse.
- D. a Mughal observatory.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Tughlaqabad proclaimed a new regime through a fortified, sloping-wall architectural idiom.

Broad MCQ 03

Question: Which is the safest statement regarding Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq's death?

- A. It is fully proved as a saintly curse.
- B. It is fully proved as a deliberate murder by Muhammad bin Tughlaq.
- C. The secure event is the pavilion collapse; conspiracy and curse narratives belong to layered and disputed source traditions.
- D. There is no source at all about the event.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The package separates secure event, suspicion and legend instead of choosing certainty where the evidence does not.

Broad MCQ 04

Question: Why are Muhammad bin Tughlaq's policies better read through a state-capacity lens than a personality caricature?

- A. Because his reign had no relation to geography.
- B. Because every policy succeeded once correctly explained.
- C. Because he never faced military problems.
- D. Because many policies had intelligible aims but demanded coordination, trust and information that the Sultanate could not reliably supply.

Answer: D.

Explanation: The state-capacity lens explains why rational aims could yield coercive failure.

Broad MCQ 05

Question: The choice of Daulatabad was politically meaningful chiefly because:

- A. Devagiri was already a strategic Deccan base and more central to the enlarged imperial space.
- B. it lay closest to Tibet.
- C. it had no settled population.
- D. it had never been touched by Delhi before.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Daulatabad was chosen from an existing strategic logic, not at random.

Broad MCQ 06

Question: Which statement corrects the standard textbook exaggeration about the Daulatabad move?

- A. The move affected only Bengal.
- B. Pressure fell especially on elites and service groups, while Delhi remained inhabited and continued to function.
- C. Coins ceased to be struck in Delhi forever.
- D. No one moved at all.

Answer: B.

Explanation: The secure correction is against total depopulation, not against all coercion.

Broad MCQ 07

Question: Muhammad bin Tughlaq's token-currency experiment should NOT be described as:

- A. fiduciary coinage.
- B. a policy undermined by forgery.
- C. paper currency.
- D. a monetary experiment tied to credibility.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The package explicitly rejects the common but incorrect label "paper currency."

Broad MCQ 08

Question: What most directly ruined the token-currency experiment?

- A. A total absence of military expenditure.
- B. Refusal of all nobles to accept any metal coin.
- C. The closing of all mints by order of Firuz Shah.
- D. Failure to maintain trust by controlling authentication and counterfeiting.

Answer: D.

Explanation: The issue was not novelty alone but the state's weak monopoly over verification.

Broad MCQ 09

Question: Which feature of the doab policy most sharply increased the effective burden on cultivators?

- A. Assessment by standard yield and official prices rather than actual output and market reality.
- B. Replacing officials with village assemblies only.
- C. Complete abolition of revenue demand.
- D. Free canal irrigation for all India.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Standard-yield rigidity under stress was central to the crisis.

Broad MCQ 10

Question: Muhammad bin Tughlaq's move to Swargadwari in the famine phase indicates:

- A. his conversion into a forest ascetic.
- B. the severity of scarcity and pestilential conditions around Delhi during the agrarian crisis.
- C. permanent abandonment of Delhi for Bengal.
- D. the start of the Bahmani kingdom.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Swargadwari belongs to the relief-and-crisis sequence linked to the doab distress and famine.

Broad MCQ 11

Question: The most careful interpretation of Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi is that it aimed to:

- A. create a seaborne customs network.
- B. destroy cultivated land in the doab.
- C. extend cultivation onto banjar land while improving crops through loans and supervision.
- D. replace nobles with village priests.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The advanced OCR encourages the more precise reading of agricultural extension rather than impossible cultivation of unusable soil.

Broad MCQ 12

Question: What is the safest caution when discussing the Khurasan project?

- A. It had no relation to the north-west frontier.

- B. It was identical to the Qarachil expedition.
- C. It certainly conquered Iraq.
- D. Chroniclers inflate its scale and aim, so it should be treated as a strategic frontier project rather than automatic proof of world-conquest fantasy.

Answer: D.

Explanation: The package keeps the project within a strategic frontier frame and marks exaggerated chronicler claims.

Broad MCQ 13

Question: The Qarachil expedition is best described as:

- A. a Himalayan campaign wrecked by terrain and over-extension.
- B. a purely maritime expedition to Arabia.
- C. the founding of Firozabad.
- D. the abolition of jizya.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Qarachil belongs to mountain logistics, not to China or overseas war.

Broad MCQ 14

Question: Which statement best connects Muhammad bin Tughlaq's southern losses to later regional states?

- A. Delhi's southern failures automatically created a stable pan-Indian federation.
- B. Plague, distance and repeated rebellion weakened Delhi's direct rule, creating the setting for successor powers such as Vijayanagara and Bahmani.
- C. The south remained completely unaffected by Delhi's crises.
- D. Bengal created the Bahmani state.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Topic 05 treats Vijayanagara and Bahmani as outcomes of Delhi overstretch, while full state histories remain elsewhere.

Broad MCQ 15

Question: Barani's complaints about Muhammad bin Tughlaq appointing "mean and ignoble" men are most valuable because they reveal:

- A. that all service castes ruled the empire successfully.
- B. that no such officials ever existed.
- C. elite resentment at widened recruitment and changing access to office.
- D. the end of Persian as a court language.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The phrase is evidence about aristocratic ideology as much as about administration.

Broad MCQ 16

Question: What is the chief limitation of Ibn Battuta for reconstructing the Tughlaq state?

- A. He never visited India.
- B. He served only Firuz Shah.
- C. He wrote only about Gupta temples.
- D. He is strongest on courtly and travel experience, not on comprehensive village-level structural data.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Ibn Battuta is vivid and valuable, but his genre and location limit the scope of his evidence.

Broad MCQ 17

Question: Muhammad bin Tughlaq's turn toward caliphal investiture and the Caliph's name on coins is best explained as:

- A. an attempt to answer orthodox hostility by reinforcing symbolic legitimacy.
- B. a rejection of all Islamic political language.
- C. a sign that Bengal had become the capital.
- D. a revenue measure to fund canal digging under Firuz.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Caliphal symbolism was used to answer critics, though it did not fully solve the legitimacy problem.

Broad MCQ 18

Question: Firuz Shah's accession differed from Muhammad bin Tughlaq's imperial style because Firuz:

- A. ended all concern for revenue.
- B. accepted a smaller, more governable horizon and sought stability through conciliation.
- C. immediately reconquered the deep south.
- D. abandoned urban building.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Firuz's political bargain rested on governability, not on renewed all-India direct-rule ambition.

Broad MCQ 19

Question: The hereditary transfer of offices and iqta's under Firuz Shah most clearly encouraged:

- A. stronger meritocracy.
- B. permanent elimination of noble privilege.
- C. entrenchment of office-holding families and weakening of central discipline.
- D. the disappearance of rural revenue assignments.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Heredity reduced rebellion in the short run but deepened long-run oligarchic weakness.

Broad MCQ 20

Question: Why is Firuz Shah's jizya policy important for Topic 05?

- A. It proves that all other taxes vanished overnight.
- B. It had no relation to orthodoxy.
- C. It shows that Brahmins became army commanders by right.
- D. It illustrates Firuz's sharper juristic ordering of rule, including denial of the earlier practical Brahmin exemption.

Answer: D.

Explanation: The jizya issue is central to understanding Firuz's combination of benevolence and orthodoxy.

Broad MCQ 21

Question: Under Firuz Shah, many soldiers of the central army were paid through:

- A. village-revenue assignments known as *wajh*.
- B. a fully salaried navy based at Cambay.
- C. temple management rights in Odisha.
- D. only imported Venetian silver.

Answer: A.

Explanation: The advanced OCR explicitly notes payment through village assignments, reinforcing heredity and localisation.

Broad MCQ 22

Question: In Topic 05, *haqq-i-sharb* is best understood as:

- A. the salary of Ibn Battuta.
- B. a water due or irrigation tax linked to canal benefit.
- C. a slave-market cess.
- D. a tax on paper manuscripts.

Answer: B.

Explanation: It refers to an irrigation-related levy, not to a general trade or market tax.

Broad MCQ 23

Question: Which statement about Firuz Shah's architectural and urban activity is the safest?

- A. He had no connection at all with Hauz Khas or Kotla.
- B. Every later city in north India was entirely his foundation.
- C. He founded or renewed important urban sites, repaired earlier monuments and must be discussed with careful attribution rather than inflated total credit.
- D. He destroyed all older monuments and built only new ones.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Attribution must be precise: Firuz was a major builder and repairer, but not the sole creator of every later urban centre.

Broad MCQ 24

Question: The movement of the Topra and Meerut Ashokan pillars to Delhi is most important because it demonstrates:

- A. Firuz Shah's rejection of older political symbols.
- B. that Tughlaq rulers lacked engineering knowledge.
- C. the end of all inscriptional culture.
- D. a fusion of technical transport skill, prestige appropriation and dynastic self-display.

Answer: D.

Explanation: The pillar episode is both a technological feat and an ideological act.

Broad MCQ 25

Question: The Diwan-i-Bandagan is best described as:

- A. an organised apparatus managing a large body of slaves for labour, service and political dependence.
- B. a voluntary marriage bureau.
- C. a mint-control office for token currency.
- D. a literary academy founded by Ibn Battuta.

Answer: A.

Explanation: The institution tied slave labour, palace service and power politics together.

Broad MCQ 26

Question: What is the sharpest limitation in calling Firuz Shah a "welfare monarch"?

- A. He ruled only in the Deccan.
- B. Much of the benevolence was selective, politically useful and concentrated among favoured or respectable groups rather than universally distributed.
- C. He never undertook any charitable measure.
- D. He abolished all hospitals.

Answer: B.

Explanation: The welfare label needs qualification because beneficiaries and motives were selective.

Broad MCQ 27

Question: Firuz Shah's patronage of translations from Sanskrit into Persian should lead to which conclusion?

- A. Orthodoxy disappeared from the reign.
- B. Jizya lost all significance.
- C. Cultural interest and orthodox state-marking could coexist in the same reign.
- D. The ulema had no role in politics.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Translation patronage does not cancel the evidence for sharper juristic orthodoxy.

Broad MCQ 28

Question: Firuz Shah's claim to have reduced mutilatory punishment should be read as:

- A. a meaningless invention unsupported by any source tradition.
- B. proof that coercion vanished from the Sultanate.
- C. evidence that no rebellion occurred after 1351.
- D. part of a benevolent self-presentation that reduced one style of punishment without eliminating power or coercion.

Answer: D.

Explanation: The package treats the claim as meaningful but not as proof of a non-coercive state.

Broad MCQ 29

Question: Which summary of Firuz Shah's military career is the safest?

- A. Mixed campaigns in Bengal, Jajnagar, Nagarkot and Sindh, combined with refusal to attempt southern reconquest.
- B. Complete military inactivity.
- C. Total reconquest of the south and Bengal alike.
- D. Exclusive focus on sea-borne warfare.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Firuz campaigned, but with limited durable results and no return to Muhammad's southern ambition.

Broad MCQ 30

Question: Firuz Shah's repeated search for caliphal investiture is best interpreted as:

- A. a sign that Firuz abandoned Islam.
- B. a symbolic reinforcement of legitimacy rather than a source of real executive power.
- C. evidence that Bengal had accepted his suzerainty permanently.
- D. proof that the Caliph directly governed Delhi.

Answer: B.

Explanation: By Firuz's time, caliphal prestige remained useful symbolically even though practical power lay elsewhere.

Broad MCQ 31

Question: Why must the *Futuh-i Firuz Shahi* be read carefully?

- A. Because it deals only with Portuguese trade.
- B. Because it contains no political material.
- C. Because it is a ruler's self-presentation and must be checked against other narrative and material evidence.
- D. Because it was written by Chengiz Khan.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The *Futuhat* is valuable precisely because it reveals how Firuz wanted to be remembered.

Broad MCQ 32

Question: Which comparison most clearly distinguishes Muhammad bin Tughlaq from Firuz Shah?

- A. Muhammad and Firuz both relied only on saints.
- B. Muhammad ruled a smaller territory than Firuz.
- C. Muhammad disliked administration while Firuz invented it.
- D. Muhammad pursued high-risk innovation and direct supervision, whereas Firuz sought durable calm through conciliation and heredity.

Answer: D.

Explanation: This contrast captures the package's core comparative framework.

Broad MCQ 33

Question: Which factor most directly worsened post-1388 instability?

- A. Interaction of hereditary office, factional nobles, ambitious princes and the slave corps.
- B. Immediate reconquest of Madurai by Delhi.
- C. Elimination of all provincial governors.
- D. Permanent unity between princes and wazirs.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Succession weakness was cumulative and involved more than one courtly constituency.

Broad MCQ 34

Question: Timur's later invasion should be connected to Topic 05 in which way?

- A. As proof that Firuz recovered the Deccan.
- B. As a culminating shock that struck a Sultanate already weakened by earlier structural and succession problems.
- C. As the single original cause of Tughlaq decline.
- D. As an event of Muhammad bin Tughlaq's youth.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Topic 05 builds the preconditions; Topic 06 owns the full Timur narrative.

Broad MCQ 35

Question: Why is the Tughlaq phase historically significant in the larger Sultanate story?

- A. It ended all north-south political contact.
- B. It eliminated regional states permanently.
- C. It combined the widest Delhi reach, dramatic over-stretch, Deccan political consequences and important northern irrigation-public-works initiatives.
- D. It introduced no notable administrative or political shift.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The Tughlaq age is historically important both for expansion and for the visible limits of such expansion.

Broad MCQ 36

Question: The most defensible historiographical line on Muhammad bin Tughlaq is that he was:

- A. a saintly planner betrayed only by fate.
- B. a ruler whose every policy was modern and democratic.
- C. simply insane and therefore beyond analysis.
- D. an ambitious ruler with many rational aims whose sequencing, coercion and compliance mechanisms repeatedly failed.

Answer: D.

Explanation: This avoids both caricature and romantic rescue.

Broad MCQ 37

Question: The most defensible historiographical line on Firuz Shah is that he was:

- A. a benevolent developmental ruler whose public works coexisted with heredity, orthodoxy and long-run central weakening.
- B. a ruler about whom only European evidence exists.
- C. uninterested in agriculture or towns.
- D. identical in method to Muhammad bin Tughlaq.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Firuz's reputation must include both developmental initiatives and institutional softening.

Broad MCQ 38

Question: Which architectural feature is most closely associated with Tughlaq style in this package?

- A. Neo-classical porticoes.
- B. Battered or sloping walls combined with an austere fortified idiom.
- C. Extensive marble pietra dura panels.
- D. Circular Buddhist railings.

Answer: B.

Explanation: The package repeatedly uses the sloping-wall fortified style as a Tughlaq marker.

Broad MCQ 39

Question: Why are coins, canals, forts and pillars important alongside chronicles in Topic 05?

- A. They matter only for ancient history.
- B. They prove that every chronicle number is exact.
- C. They anchor claims in material action while reminding us that physical survival does not automatically equal full administrative control.
- D. They replace all written sources completely.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Material evidence is a corrective, not an omniscient substitute.

Broad MCQ 40

Question: Which one-line conclusion best sums up this workbook's argument?

- A. Policy failure proves absence of purpose.
- B. Benevolence alone guarantees stability.
- C. Medieval rule can be explained entirely through morality tales.
- D. The Tughlaq story is best read through the fit - or misfit - between ambition, information, coercion, revenue and elite management.

Answer: D.

Explanation: This is the package's master analytical sentence.

Remedial MCQs - trap-correction set

Rotation check rule: This third original sequence restarts at **A** and rotates strictly through **B, C, D**.

Remedial MCQ 01

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "Muhammad emptied Delhi completely"?

- A. He imposed severe movement pressure, but mainly on elites and associated groups; Delhi remained inhabited and functioning.

- B. Daulatabad never existed.
- C. No movement occurred at all.
- D. Only Bengal was moved.

Answer: A.

Explanation: The right correction is against total depopulation, not against coercion itself.

Remedial MCQ 02

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "Muhammad introduced paper currency"?

- A. Firuz Shah introduced it after 1351.
- B. The experiment used copper-and-brass token coinage, not paper currency.
- C. The policy abolished coinage.
- D. The currency was only ceremonial gold.

Answer: B.

Explanation: This is one of the most common textbook mistakes and must be removed immediately.

Remedial MCQ 03

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "Muhammad bin Tughlaq was simply mad"?

- A. Every policy succeeded perfectly.
- B. He never planned anything at all.
- C. Many policies had rational aims, but their sequencing and enforcement outran the state's capacity.
- D. Chroniclers never criticised him.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The state-capacity lens beats both caricature and romantic overcorrection.

Remedial MCQ 04

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "Qarachil was an expedition to conquer China"?

- A. Qarachil was a canal.
- B. Qarachil was a Portuguese embassy.
- C. Qarachil took place in Bengal.
- D. Qarachil was a Himalayan campaign whose later "China" label is historically misleading.

Answer: D.

Explanation: The package explicitly separates the mountain-campaign reality from later exaggeration.

Remedial MCQ 05

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "Diwan-i-Kohi proves absurd farming of impossible desert land only"?

- A. The more careful reading is agricultural extension onto banjar land with loans and supervision, though badly implemented.
- B. It was actually a minting reform.
- C. It belonged to Firuz Shah's hospitals.
- D. It had no relation to cultivation.

Answer: A.

Explanation: The objective was risky but intelligible; the failure lay in execution.

Remedial MCQ 06

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "Firuz Shah created a modern welfare state"?

- A. He hated public works.
- B. His benevolence was real but selective, politically useful and embedded in a medieval social hierarchy.

- C. No chronicler mentions charity under him.
- D. He ruled only temple priests.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Social selectivity is essential to any accurate description of Firuz's benevolence.

Remedial MCQ 07

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "hereditary iqtas were an unqualified administrative success"?

- A. Heredity instantly revived the Deccan.
- B. Heredity ended all faction.
- C. The policy purchased short-term calm but weakened merit, discipline and central control in the long run.
- D. The policy abolished all noble privilege.

Answer: C.

Explanation: This is the central limitation of Firuz's conciliation strategy.

Remedial MCQ 08

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "translation patronage proves Firuz Shah was not orthodox"?

- A. Jizya disappeared after translations began.
- B. Translation and orthodoxy can never coexist.
- C. Firuz did not patronise any translation at all.
- D. Translation patronage coexisted with sharper juristic ordering, jizya enforcement and temple-related coercion.

Answer: D.

Explanation: The reign must be read as a combination, not as a one-word identity.

Remedial MCQ 09

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "the slave department was mainly a welfare institution"?

- A. It organised coerced labour, service and political dependence rather than universal social protection.
- B. It was a merchants' port trust.
- C. It built Tughlaqabad before 1320.
- D. It regulated Brahman taxes only.

Answer: A.

Explanation: The slave institution was part of court power and labour control.

Remedial MCQ 10

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "Firuz's canals transformed every corner of the old Delhi empire equally"?

- A. The canals were built by Timur.
- B. The works were concentrated in the north-Indian core and should not be inflated into empire-wide equal development.
- C. There were no canals at all.
- D. All canals were in Bengal only.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Spatial concentration is essential to understanding Firuz's developmental model.

Remedial MCQ 11

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "Barani's dramatic numbers and moral language can be taken literally throughout"?

- A. His account was written by Ibn Battuta.
- B. Barani is useless and should be ignored.

- C. Barani is indispensable but rhetorical, later and aristocratic, so his claims require cross-checking and minimum-secure phrasing.
- D. Material evidence can never check narrative.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The correct method is critical use, not blind faith or total rejection.

Remedial MCQ 12

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "Timur alone caused the fall of the Tughlaqs"?

- A. Firuz's succession arrangements had already solved instability.
- B. No decline had begun before 1398.
- C. Timur restored the Tughlaqs.
- D. Timur struck a Sultanate already weakened by heredity, faction, provincial assertion and succession crises.

Answer: D.

Explanation: The package places Timur as a culminating shock, not as the sole originating cause.

Semantic-completeness coverage drills - Medieval Topic 05

Drill	Prompt	Minimum answer route	Fatal trap
A	Assess Daulatabad.	objective -> affected groups/phases -> coercion -> reversal -> afterlife	whole Delhi emptied
B	Explain token failure.	metal token -> issue/authentication -> counterfeiting -> redemption -> limits	fiat/paper analogy
C	Analyse Doab/Kohi.	assessment/collection + famine -> relief -> loans/agriculture -> monitoring	one failure cause
D	Separate Khurasan/Qarachil.	plan/recruitment/treasury versus expedition/terrain/loss	China invasion
E	Explain southern contraction.	Ma'bar/Warangal/Kampili -> plague/rebellion/distance -> new states	one rebellion
F	Assess Firuz's works.	canal/town/hospital/education/charity -> regional/evidence limit	precise welfare census
G	Evaluate Firuz's state bargain.	heredity/audit/iqta/wajh -> peace -> military/faction cost	feudal ownership
H	Compare rulers.	objectives -> capacity -> instruments -> outcomes -> long-term fragility	genius versus failure

PYQ status: one direct routed question (2021 Q38) and three adjacent applications.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

PYQ verification ledger and scope honesty

- **PYQ 01 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2021** (directly relevant; statement wording verified locally; option row partially garbled in OCR, reconstructed only where secure).
- **PYQ 02 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2022** (adjacent but directly useful for Tughlaq-era Mongol chronology; wording verified locally).
- **PYQ 03 - UPSC GS-I 2020** (adjacent source-criticism Mains question; wording preserved verbatim in repository and prior validated packages).
- **PYQ 04 - UPSC GS-I 2023** (adjacent broader Sultanate-technology question; wording preserved verbatim in repository and prior validated packages).
- [LIMIT] Official Prelims answer keys for the locally used paper copies are not bundled with the evidence read in this export. Where the repository already uses a high-confidence inferred answer, that status is preserved explicitly

as **inferred**, not falsely upgraded.

Verified and honestly-adjacent PYQs

Direct PYQ 01 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2021 (direct routed relevance; statement wording verified locally; option row partly garbled in local OCR)

Question as securely verified from the local paper OCR: Consider the following statements:

1. It was during the reign of Iltutmish that Chengiz Khan reached the Indus in pursuit of the fugitive Khwarezm prince.
2. It was during the reign of Muhammad bin Tughluq that Taimur occupied Multan and crossed the Indus.
3. It was during the reign of Deva Raya II of Vijayanagara Empire that Vasco da Gama reached the coast of Kerala.

Option row status: The local OCR preserves the options imperfectly, but the repository's earlier validated usage supports the standard combination row containing **1 only**, **1 and 2**, **3 only**, and **2 and 3**.

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: 1 only. Confidence: high.

Model explanation: Statement 1 is correct: Chengiz Khan reached the Indus while pursuing Jalal al-Din Mangburni during Iltutmish's reign. Statement 2 is incorrect because Timur's invasion belongs to the post-Firuz, post-Tughlaq-weakening phase and culminates in 1398-99, long after Muhammad bin Tughlaq. Statement 3 is incorrect because Vasco da Gama reached Kerala in 1498, during the age of a much later Vijayanagara ruler, not Deva Raya II.

Why this earns marks: It secures chronology by dynastic phase and stops the common trap of mechanically pairing "Muhammad bin Tughlaq" with every major north-western episode.

Demand decoding: Treat "PYQ 01 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2021 (direct routed relevance; statement wording verified...)" as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "PYQ 01 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2021 (direct routed relevance; statement wording verified...)", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

Adjacent PYQ 02 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2022 (adjacent frontier chronology question; exact wording verified locally)

Question: With reference to Indian history, consider the following statements:

1. The first Mongol invasion of India happened during the reign of Jalal-ud-din Khalji.
2. During the reign of Ala-ud-din Khalji, one Mongol assault marched up to Delhi and besieged the city.
3. Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq temporarily lost portions of north-west of his kingdom to Mongols.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 and 2 (b) 2 only (c) 1 and 3 (d) 3 only

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: (b) 2 only. Confidence: high.

Model explanation: Statement 1 is incorrect because Mongol pressure predates Jalaluddin Khalji and belongs to an older north-western frontier chronology. Statement 2 is correct because the 1303 Targhi crisis brought Mongol pressure up to Delhi during Alauddin's reign. Statement 3 is unsafe as phrased and is not supported by the secure event-line used in this repository for Muhammad's frontier troubles.

Why this earns marks: It separates general Mongol pressure from specific Delhi-siege events and refuses to validate a statement merely because a familiar Tughlaq ruler is named.

Demand decoding: Treat "With reference to Indian history, consider the following statements: 1. The first Mongol..." as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where

available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For “With reference to Indian history, consider the following statements: 1. The first Mongol...”, add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

Adjacent PYQ 03 - UPSC GS-I 2020 (adjacent but highly useful source-criticism question; wording preserved in repository)

Question: Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

Persian literary sources are indispensable for the Delhi Sultanate because they preserve the political language, moral anxieties and courtly horizons of the age. Yet they reflect the spirit of the age only when read with **genre, patronage and author-position caution**.

Topic 05 offers an ideal demonstration. **Barani** is central for Muhammad bin Tughlaq's token currency, Daulatabad, doab crisis and elite theory. But he was a later aristocratic moralist with open prejudice against the "low and ignoble"; his accounts often magnify exemplary success or failure to teach political lessons. **Isami** is useful for Deccan dislocation and Delhi overreach, but he writes from displacement and retrospective memory. **Ibn Battuta** gives vivid evidence on court ritual, punishments, gifts, roads and city-life under Muhammad, yet his traveller's gaze highlights the remarkable rather than the statistically normal. Under Firuz, **Afif** and the *Futuh-i Firuz Shahi* show public works, benevolence and orthodoxy, but they also stage the ruler's preferred self-image.

These texts therefore reflect not a neutral mirror-image of society, but the **refracted political culture** of their age: ideas of just rule, elite resentment, religious legitimacy, expansion, urbanity and fear. When paired with coins, canals, monuments and inscriptions, they become even more powerful.

Hence Persian literary sources do reflect the spirit of the age, but the spirit they reveal is courtly, argumentative and mediated - never transparent fact.

Why this earns marks: It uses Topic 05's source bank directly, names authors, explains what each source proves, and converts "reflect" into a method question rather than a slogan.

Demand decoding: The directive **comment** requires a direct position on “Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (Answer...)”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (Answer...)”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Adjacent PYQ 04 - UPSC GS-I 2023 (adjacent broader Sultanate question; wording preserved in repository)

Question: What were the major technological changes introduced during the Sultanate period? How did those technological changes influence the Indian society? (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

The Sultanate period mattered technologically not because it created an entirely new civilisation, but because it accelerated the diffusion and combination of techniques in construction, military administration, irrigation and craft production. Their influence was strongest in **state capacity, urban growth and social differentiation**.

In construction, the stronger use of the **true arch, dome and lime mortar** enlarged the scale of buildings and changed the skyline of power. Topic 05's Tughlaq phase reveals a further turn toward battered defensive walls, elevated platforms and large repair projects under Firuz. In irrigation, canals associated with Firuz Shah show technology as agrarian development and revenue policy, not merely engineering. Their impact lay in settlement growth, cultivation expansion and the strengthening of the north-Indian core.

Administrative technology also mattered. Horse-branding, descriptive rolls and revenue audit systems show that information itself was a technology of rule. Even Muhammad bin Tughlaq's token-currency scheme, though it failed, belonged to the same world of technical experimentation tied to fiscal governance.

The social effect was uneven. These changes empowered states, towns, merchants, military systems and courtly centres more than they democratised society. Monumental architecture, canals and money policies deepened stratification even while widening circulation and urban connection.

Thus Sultanate technological change shaped Indian society by linking technique to power, production and urban order.

Why this earns marks: It answers both parts, uses Tughlaq-era examples rather than generic listing, and converts technology into social consequence.

Original solved Mains practice

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "What were the major technological changes introduced during the Sultanate period? How did...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "What were the major technological changes introduced during the Sultanate period? How did...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Original Mains 01 - 10 marks - 150 words

Question: Assess the importance of Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq's short reign for understanding the wider Tughlaq age.

Model answer:

Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq matters less for duration than for **transition**. He ended the Khusrau Khan crisis in 1320 and restored dynastic legitimacy after the late Khalji collapse. His reign also established the tone from which Muhammad bin Tughlaq later departed.

First, the local OCR stresses Ghiyasuddin's **moderation**: taxation should sustain agriculture and crafts rather than destroy them. This is important because Topic 05 later contrasts it with Muhammad's harder and more uniform fiscal push in the doab.

Second, Ghiyasuddin renewed imperial assertion. Warangal was re-secured through Ulugh Khan and Bengal was campaigned against successfully. Thus Muhammad did not inherit a broken shell; he inherited an energised but still consolidating state.

Third, Tughlaqabad and Ghiyasuddin's tomb announced a new dynastic style - fortified, austere and authority-centred.

Finally, his death after the Bengal return is itself a lesson in source criticism: pavilion collapse is secure, conspiracy certainty is not.

Hence Ghiyasuddin's brief reign is the hinge between Khalji breakdown and the larger Tughlaq experiment in empire.

Why this earns marks: It shows transition, policy tone, imperial handoff and source criticism in one compact structure.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on "Assess the importance of Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq's short reign for understanding the wider...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Assess the importance of Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq's short reign for understanding the wider...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Original Mains 02 - 10 marks - 150 words

Question: Why should the Daulatabad and token-currency measures of Muhammad bin Tughlaq be analysed as problems of administrative credibility rather than as mere eccentricity?

Model answer:

Both Daulatabad and token currency had intelligible aims, but both required a level of **credible compliance** that the Sultanate could not sustain.

Daulatabad was not random whim. Devagiri was already a strategic Deccan base, and a second-capital model could have improved supervision over the south. The policy failed because migration was coercive, distance was punishing, and the southern direct-rule project itself weakened. The centre could not make the burden appear legitimate for long enough.

Token currency likewise was not absurd in conception. Fiduciary money had wider precedents. The failure came because the state could not monopolise authentication; unofficial imitation spread and trust collapsed.

In both cases, the question is not whether the ruler "had an idea," but whether roads, local cooperation, mint control, public trust and follow-through existed. They did not exist in sufficient strength.

Therefore, these measures are best treated as credibility failures of a high-ambition state, not as evidence of random madness.

Why this earns marks: It links two famous policies through one analytical thread - credibility - and moves beyond stock storytelling.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "Why should the Daulatabad and token-currency measures of Muhammad bin Tughlaq be analysed...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Why should the Daulatabad and token-currency measures of Muhammad bin Tughlaq be analysed...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Original Mains 03 - 15 marks - 250 words

Question: Examine how the doab crisis, Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi and the Khurasan/Qarachil episodes reveal the limits of Muhammad bin Tughlaq's state capacity.

Model answer:

Muhammad bin Tughlaq's reign reveals a ruler trying to make a vast empire fiscally legible and strategically secure. The doab crisis, Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi and the Khurasan/Qarachil episodes show that his **objectives were often rational, but his instruments were too brittle**.

In the **doab**, the state relied on standard yield and official prices rather than actual local conditions. Under famine-like stress and harsh collection, the effective burden became explosive. This shows an information problem: the centre could demand, but it could not adapt quickly enough to ecological and local realities.

The **Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi** shows another limit. The objective - extend cultivation and improve crops through loans - was developmental. Yet honest local supervision, agronomic knowledge and recovery discipline were weak. Funds were misused, and the measure failed administratively.

The **Khurasan project** and **Qarachil expedition** display the military side of the same problem. A strategic forward move toward the north-west required sustainable finance and dependable purpose; a mountain campaign required terrain-sensitive logistics. Neither requirement was adequately met.

Across all three cases, the pattern is clear: the Sultanate could imagine larger scales of extraction, improvement and frontier control than it could enforce credibly.

Thus Muhammad's failure was not absence of thought, but a mismatch between imperial ambition and operational capacity.

Why this earns marks: It answers through a common concept - state capacity - and integrates fiscal, developmental and military evidence.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on "Examine how the doab crisis, Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi and the Khurasan/Qarachil episodes reveal...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Examine how the doab crisis, Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi and the Khurasan/Qarachil episodes reveal...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Original Mains 04 - 15 marks - 250 words

Question: Discuss Firuz Shah Tughlaq's public works and benevolence. To what extent did they strengthen, and to what extent did they soften, the Delhi Sultanate?

Model answer:

Firuz Shah strengthened the Sultanate in the short run by reorienting rule toward **public works, agrarian recovery and elite reassurance**, but he softened key institutions whose weakness became visible after his death.

On the strengthening side, Firuz built canals from the Sutlej and Yamuna systems into the Haryana-Delhi tract, encouraged new cultivation, founded or renewed towns such as Firozabad and Hissar-Firuz, repaired monuments, built hospitals and organised charity. These measures improved the core north-Indian zone economically and ideologically. They helped present the state as beneficent rather than merely punitive.

Yet the same reign softened the Sultanate structurally. Nobles gained heredity in office and iqta. Soldiers increasingly held revenue assignments and service became hereditary. Audit terror receded, but so did discipline. The slave corps, meant as a pool of dependent manpower, became another political bloc.

Religious legitimacy also came at a cost. Firuz's sharper orthodoxy, separate jizya and temple-related coercion pleased sections of the ulema but narrowed the ideological coalition of rule.

Therefore, Firuz strengthened the **core landscape and immediate legitimacy** of the Sultanate, but softened the **central coercive and administrative edge** on which long-run durability depended.

Why this earns marks: It gives a balanced verdict and measures success in two time-scales - immediate and long-term.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on "Discuss Firuz Shah Tughlaq's public works and benevolence. To what extent did they...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Discuss Firuz Shah Tughlaq's public works and benevolence. To what extent did they...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Original Mains 05 - 20 marks - 250 words

Question: Compare Muhammad bin Tughlaq and Firuz Shah Tughlaq in terms of ambition, fiscal strategy, elite management and durability of rule.

Model answer:

Muhammad bin Tughlaq and Firuz Shah Tughlaq represent two sharply different responses to the same Delhi-Sultanate problem: how to hold together a large and diverse empire from a northern core.

In **ambition**, Muhammad was maximalist. He tried to retain the Deccan under direct rule, experiment with a second capital, push fiscal extraction in the doab, attempt fiduciary coinage and contemplate forward frontier strategy. Firuz was minimalist by comparison: he accepted the loss of the south, did not seek full reconquest and concentrated on a governable northern heartland.

In **fiscal strategy**, Muhammad relied on heavy assessment, standardisation and a bold monetary measure that required strong credibility. Firuz relied more on softer collection, irrigation-led expansion, cesses-remission claims and benefits that often flowed through hereditary office-holders.

In **elite management**, Muhammad widened recruitment, bringing in foreigners and "new men," but this reduced aristocratic cohesion and fed chronicler resentment. Firuz preferred conciliation: high salaries, heredity in office and reduced audit pressure. This bought peace but encouraged oligarchic closure.

In **durability**, Muhammad's innovations collapsed quickly when trust, climate and compliance failed. Firuz's peace lasted longer, but the institutions underneath became softer: the army lost sharpness, nobles entrenched themselves, and succession became fragile.

Thus Muhammad over-strained the Sultanate's capacity, while Firuz undercut its central edge. One failed through overreach; the other through over-accommodation.

Why this earns marks: It compares ruler to ruler across four specified dimensions and gives a nuanced final contrast instead of a moral ranking.

Demand decoding: The directive **compare** requires a direct position on "Compare Muhammad bin Tughlaq and Firuz Shah Tughlaq in terms of ambition, fiscal strategy,...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Compare Muhammad bin Tughlaq and Firuz Shah Tughlaq in terms of ambition, fiscal strategy,...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Original Mains 06 - 20 marks - 250 words

Question: Historiography often contrasts Muhammad bin Tughlaq as a "visionary failure" and Firuz Shah as a "welfare ruler." Critically examine both labels.

Model answer:

Both labels contain a fragment of truth but become misleading when used without institutional analysis.

Muhammad bin Tughlaq can be called **visionary** only in the limited sense that several of his policies had rational and far-reaching objectives: a more central imperial capital pattern, wider monetary circulation, developmental cultivation and a forward strategic frontier. But "failure" must be explained, not moralised. The failure lay in weak compliance mechanisms - coercive migration without durable consent, token currency without mint control, agrarian development without honest local supervision and strategic projects without stable logistics. The label is useful only if converted into a **state-capacity diagnosis**.

Firuz Shah can be called a **welfare ruler** because he invested in canals, hospitals, marriage assistance, charity, gardens, repairs and urban works. Yet the label becomes romantic if it hides selectivity, political utility and exclusion. Much benevolence favoured core-region and respectable beneficiaries, while the same reign deepened heredity in office, empowered the slave corps, tightened juristic hierarchy and made jizya a sharper marker.

Therefore, neither label should be discarded entirely, but both must be disciplined. Muhammad was not a mad eccentric; Firuz was not a universally benevolent developmental king. Each ruler's reputation becomes historically meaningful only when linked to **who benefited, who obeyed, what instrument was used and what endured**.

Why this earns marks: It turns two familiar labels into a critical historiography answer anchored in evidence and qualification.

Demand decoding: The directive **critically examine** requires a direct position on "Historiography often contrasts Muhammad bin Tughlaq as a "visionary failure" and Firuz Shah...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Historiography often contrasts Muhammad bin Tughlaq as a "visionary failure" and Firuz Shah...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.